impossible for elite women who had to be irreproachable in their purity. And so to further ensure that all these many women with their female attendants were kept beyond the temptation of any sexual lapse, a physical space was devised, the zenana deorhi or rawala, which was the equivalent of the Rajput purdah.

The zenana in a Rajput household did not open directly into the main entrance of the home. Instead, a wall known as a pardi hid the main entrance to the women's apartments. Not even a glimpse of these women could now be seen by anyone outside of the zenana. As the rules of the feudal structure became stricter, the purdah of elite women became a symbol of a ruler's prestige and power. The more exalted the ruler, the higher were the zenana walls and the smaller the windows, the women obliterated behind the stone walls. The entrance to the zenana was guarded by deorhidars and eunuchs. The only males who were allowed entrance, apart from the ruler and the immediate family of the women, were priests, and the sons of davris, the hereditary female slaves who were part of the women's dowries. Curtains would be held up at the entrance to the zenana if state matters needed to be discussed. Purdah was also used to enforce rules of hierarchy within the bustling zenana and so the wives of a ruler were made to use the ghoonghat, a cover for the head, in front of their mothers-in-law and senior women of the zenana, whom they were not allowed to speak to directly for years after their marriage. In this the Rajput women differed from the Mughals, who were never expected to hide themselves from other women. So forbidding did the idea of purdah become that even in Rajput art, while hundreds of portraits of men would be produced in the following decades, almost no paintings of actual women were ever produced, this invisibility itself, as described by historian Molly Aitken, 'a form of purdah that served to promote elite men's and elite women's different accesses to public visibility'.

In the colliding worlds of the Rajput and the Mughal, it is difficult to be sure exactly who learnt from whom, as they now increasingly had intertwined cultures and destinies. Did the Mughals adopt the Rajput notion of seclusion or did the Rajputs bolster their women with additional layers of coverings when they encountered the Mughals? Was this a defensive measure or an imitation as elite behaviour in a feudal society began to mirror the other? What is clear is that in the alchemy of this meeting, the idea of honour became inextricable from a woman's chastity, both Mughal